the same idea, saying: “Whosoever comes to Me, through whatsoever form, I reach him; all men are struggling through paths which in the end lead to me”.’[9]

This was a profoundly important idea, and central to the philosophy Vivekananda was preaching. Tolerance, after all, implies that you have the truth, but will generously indulge another who does not; you will, in an act of tolerance, allow him the right to be wrong. Acceptance, on the other hand, implies that you have a truth but the other person may also have a truth; that you accept his truth and respect it, while expecting him to respect (and accept) your truth in turn. This practice of acceptance of difference—the idea that other ways of being and believing are equally valid—is central to Hinduism and the basis for India’s democratic culture.

‘I challenge the world to find,’ Vivekananda proudly declared in a different speech in Chicago, ‘throughout the whole system of Sanskrit philosophy, any such expression as that the Hindu alone will be saved and not others. Says Vyasa, “We find perfect men even beyond the pale of our caste and creed”.’[10]

One of Hinduism’s great strengths—though there are some who see this as a weakness—is its lack of prescriptive tenets. The faith assumes that different people require different pathways to the Ultimate; even within Hinduism, there is no desire to require the same things of all people, it being accepted that people of different spiritual and intellectual attainments will employ different routes in seeking the Divine.

MULTIPLE DIVINITIES

As a result, Hindus allow themselves to worship the divine in multiple forms; the 333 million gods of legend (some versions say 33 million, 300 million and 330 million: even here we are flexible!) are in fact merely a reflection of the infinite aspects of divinity. While other faiths tend to personify the idea of God, seeing Him in anthropomorphic terms as a man-like Being, the Hindu idea of God is both simpler and more complicated. God, to the Hindu, is everywhere, a presence and an absence, within us and outside us. God transcends both time and space. God has no beginning and no end, but equally has no shape and no form.